

PROJECT SYNDICATE DIGEST

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1. America's Looming Debt Reckoning

Author: Kenneth Rogoff **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—America's fiscal position is increasingly looking like a train hurtling along a twisting mountain track. No one seems willing to slow down for fear of falling behind schedule and losing their job. Even if the train doesn't crash, it is worth asking: Why keep pushing it? Despite solid growth, the federal deficit is about 6% of GDP. Yet the option of slowing down does not appear to be in President Donald Trump's playbook.

2. Putin Is Testing NATO at Ukraine's Borders

Author: Anna Husarska **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LVIV—Jet-powered Russian drones recently hit a train in Ukraine a mere mile from the Polish border. The drone pilots, and their Kremlin minders, must have known that officials from Europe, the United Kingdom, the United States, and elsewhere had previously left Kyiv by train after participating in the Yalta European Strategy (YES) Annual Meeting, a sort of Ukrainian Davos. But the trains carrying former UK Prime Minister Boris Johnson, former Swedish Prime Minister Carl Bildt, former CIA Director David Petraeus, and former Polish President Aleksander Kwaśniewski, among others, were not hit. Had the Russians missed them intentionally or through incompetence?

3. The OECD Should Be Reclaimed, Not Abandoned

Author: Kim Ruhl **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—On September 30, the OECD marked the 65th anniversary of its founding. Like many other aging international organizations, it has developed a taste for mission creep, as we witnessed firsthand as former delegates there. That is why some US policymakers want to reduce or eliminate funding for the organization. But walking away from the OECD would mean abandoning capabilities that are becoming ever more important in America's economic competition with China.

4. The Sovereign Wealth Fund America Needs

Author: Steven Hill **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LOS ANGELES/NEW BRUNSWICK—OpenAI’s Sam Altman, US President Donald Trump, US Senator Bernie Sanders, and California Governor Gavin Newsom do not agree on much, yet they have all proposed that the United States create a sovereign wealth fund (SWF), seeded by stocks from AI companies, to cope with AI’s negative impacts. It is a good idea. Unfortunately, their proposals are woefully inadequate.

5. The Hard Road to a Middle-Power Order

Author: Sophie Eisentraut **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MUNICH—In his historic speech in Davos in January, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney urged middle powers to confront an increasingly harsh geopolitical reality by joining forces to forge a “third path” between kowtowing to great-power pressure and going it alone. But when it came to defining this path, Carney’s speech outlined two projects of very different scope.

6. Closing Europe's Dynamism Deficit

Author: Carl Benedikt Frey **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

OXFORD—Technology has always been a source of power. During the centuries when China sat near the world's frontier of invention, it was also a master of statecraft. But with the Industrial Revolution in Europe, the decisive technologies of steam, steel, railways, and rifled artillery shifted the balance of power westward, inaugurating a period embedded in China's collective memory as the "century of humiliation."

7. Why Is the Global Economy So Resilient?

Author: Nouriel Roubini

Published: Oct 2, 2026

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NEW YORK—Despite the rising risks, uncertainties, and large negative supply shocks of the last two years, stock markets and the overall global economy have held up quite well. Following the shock of US President Donald Trump’s “Liberation Day” (April 2) tariffs in 2025 came this year’s Iran War, which caused the largest energy shock since the oil crises of the 1970s.

8. Global AI Oversight Now

Author: Gabriela Ramos

Published: Oct 2, 2026

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PARIS—Several years ago, Mariana Mazzucato and I asked a simple question: Who is in charge if something goes wrong in the AI world? The question remains unanswered, even after the United Nations Security Council met last week to discuss the existential risks posed by AI.

9. Trump's Great Oil Heist

Author: Cristina Ramirez

Published: Oct 2, 2026

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LONDON—When the United States ousted Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro earlier this year and put him in a New York jail cell, Venezuelans at home and abroad rejoiced. For the first time in 27 years, the country faced a real possibility of regime change. But removing an autocrat does not necessarily dismantle the authoritarian system that kept him in power, particularly when the man who removed him is an aspiring authoritarian and kleptocrat in his own right.

10. Conserving a Connected Ocean

Author: Marie-May Jeremie

Published: Oct 2, 2026

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VICTORIA—Every year, sea turtles return to the beaches of northern KwaZulu-Natal, in South Africa, where they began life. Once they leave the shore, some travel north through the Mozambique Channel, using waters and coastal habitats off Mozambique and Madagascar, while others journey into the wider Indian Ocean. South Africa can protect their nesting beaches, but no country alone can protect their entire journey.

Governments have abandoned many of the economic ideas blamed for the populist backlash, yet support for populist parties continues to grow. This puzzle lies at the heart of two new books, both of which suggest that liberalism's decline may outlast the economic forces that set it in motion.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

The turtle embodies the central challenge of ocean conservation. Strong national action is indispensable, but protecting migratory species, interconnected habitats, and shared ecosystems requires countries to work together. And to do that, the finance supporting such cooperation must be capable of making the same journey as the turtle.

For the approximately 60 million people living within 100 kilometers (62 miles) of the Western Indian Ocean coastline, the stakes of conservation are immediate. Healthy marine ecosystems support food security, livelihoods, trade, and tourism, as well as providing bulwarks against storms. They are the natural foundation of the sustainable blue economies our countries are working to build.

But their value also reaches far beyond the region. Our mangroves and seagrasses store carbon. Our reefs sustain biodiversity. And our waters support migratory species whose journeys connect coastlines and the wider ocean. Protecting them may be a regional responsibility, but it is also in the rest of the world's interest.

Regional leaders do not lack ambition, nor are we waiting for others to define what ocean conservation should look like. In my country, Seychelles, we have seen what can happen when ambitious goals are backed by strong political commitments and innovative finance. Our marine spatial planning and conservation-finance experience demonstrates that protecting the ocean can be integrated into national development. Now, other countries across the Western Indian Ocean are pursuing similar strategies shaped by their own priorities and circumstances.

Through the Nairobi Convention, governments have committed to stronger cooperation in developing sustainable blue economies and more effective, inclusive forms of ocean governance. The Regional Ocean Governance Strategy has established the mandate, and we are all now tasked with creating the financing mechanisms capable of delivering it.

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It is a tall order. Achieving the common objective of protecting 30% of marine and coastal areas by 2030 requires more than drawing boundaries on a map. Protected areas must be supported by science, effective management, enforcement, community participation, and investments in sustainable livelihoods.

With the landmark Agreement on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction now in force, new possibilities are opening for conservation beyond national waters. The Western Indian Ocean region must be ready to influence how the agreement is implemented. Our responsibilities will extend far beyond any single project or grant. Reefs do not recover according to project deadlines, just as fisheries won't be replenished in sync with funding cycles. Conservation requires continuity.

That is why women from three coastal villages in Anjouan, Comoros, formed an association after learning from fishing communities in Madagascar and Zanzibar. They temporarily closed part of their reef to octopus fishing, helped enforce the closure, and then waited. When the fishing ground reopened, the average octopus caught was twice its previous weight. The idea crossed borders because likeminded communities were open to learning from one another.

In these and other ways, Western Indian Ocean communities are already taking the lead on conservation. But sustaining and extending their progress requires finance that supports local leadership, knowledge-sharing, and long-term ecosystem management. National institutions and project investments remain essential, but some responsibilities are regional by nature. Fisheries can move and species can migrate between interconnected habitats.

No single fund can finance every item on the conservation agenda. Pollution controls, greener ports, and other maritime priorities require different instruments. Nonetheless, governments are working toward a Western Indian Ocean Regional Conservation Trust Fund (RCTF) that can fill critical gaps, mobilizing and deploying sustained finance for priorities that cross borders and are best addressed regionally. Designed to complement and not compete with national funds, development banks, and project finance, the RCTF will focus only where cross-border cooperation adds clear value.

The region is not starting from scratch on this issue. Consultations with governments, conservation organizations, and financial partners are already ongoing, informed by lessons from near and far. But the next phase must be government-led to determine the RCTF's priorities, safeguards, governance structure, and relationship with existing institutions.

International partners can help accelerate that work. They are not being asked to create a new agenda or finance another isolated project. They can help build one component of a regionally owned financing architecture, directed toward conservation needs that conventional funding struggles to sustain. This is not simply about funding conservation in the Western Indian Ocean. The real opportunity is to invest in the region's own capacity to lead the effort.

When governments meet for the Twelfth Conference of the Parties to the Nairobi Convention (COP12) next week, they will mark 40 years of cooperation through that agreement. They must also look ahead. A sustainable blue economy for the region must be built on healthy ecosystems backed by reliable, long-term finance. The goal for the conference should be to authorize a government-led next phase for the RCTF, defining where it can add value and how it should cooperate with other regional bodies.

The Western Indian Ocean is one connected system. Its future demands finance equal to the distance its species travel, the connections its ecosystems sustain, and the ambition its countries are bringing to the table.

11. Climate Resilience Starts With Care

Author: Caren Grown **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—It is getting harder by the day to justify the slow pace of adaptation to climate change. Last year was one of the hottest on record, with economies and communities around the world disrupted by extreme heat, heavy rainfall, and tropical cyclones. As November's United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Turkey approaches, governments must move beyond climate commitments and focus on implementation.

Governments have abandoned many of the economic ideas blamed for the populist backlash, yet support for populist parties continues to grow. This puzzle lies at the heart of two new books, both of which suggest that liberalism's decline may outlast the economic forces that set it in motion.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

Financing for adaptation activities remains nowhere near what is needed. The UN Environment Programme estimates that developing countries will need \$310–365 billion per year through 2035, putting the current funding gap at \$280 billion. Getting the money to where it can do the most good may be an even bigger challenge, as institutions struggle to identify adaptation investments that are ready to implement and whose risks can be properly assessed and priced.

In a new working paper, we argue that estimates of funding needs and proposed investment pipelines overlook a critical piece of infrastructure: an ecosystem of climate-adapted care services that helps families prepare for, cope with, and recover from climate-induced hazards. Properly designed, these services can bolster household and community resilience. The same principle underpins investments in early-warning systems and adaptive social protections designed to help countries respond to climate shocks.

Provisional estimates suggest that at least 35,000 excess deaths occurred across Europe during this summer's severe back-to-back heat waves. Despite their well-developed welfare systems, the absence of climate-adapted physical infrastructure and coordinated services contributed to this excess mortality.

Yet national climate-adaptation plans rarely account for what happens when care breaks down. Floods and wildfires displace families and separate caregivers from the people who depend on them. When household-based care is no longer possible, formal care can become a lifeline for older people and people with disabilities who cannot evacuate or manage on their own. Without reliable care services, health issues can lead to otherwise preventable hospital admissions, putting even more pressure on already strained services.

As matters stand, family caregivers are left to shoulder the burden, facing injury and burnout during prolonged emergencies. Some, most of them women, are forced to leave paid work just when their families can least afford to lose income. When care systems fail, a climate shock can quickly become both a health and economic crisis. Strong care systems can prevent these cascading failures, making care a crucial part of climate resilience.

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Leaving care out of national adaptation plans thus means underestimating what climate resilience actually requires. Admittedly, anticipating those needs is difficult, as there is no standard definition of what qualifies as adaptation, and

national estimates are often based on individual projects, most of them in conventional sectors.

That sector-by-sector approach allows care to fall through the cracks. Agriculture, forestry, fishing, water supply, and sanitation account for nearly 40% of global adaptation finance, while health receives an estimated 4–6% and education around 2%. Long-term care and early-childhood care and education are essentially absent, particularly in low- and middle-income countries, where most care is provided informally.

Despite being too low, the \$310–365 billion figure is already baked into national plans and multilateral-development-bank targets. But as climate shocks intensify, people will need more care, not less. And when formal services fall short, unpaid caregivers—overwhelmingly women and girls—will end up filling the gap.

Our paper proposes a way to begin correcting that omission. For example, we estimate that building climate-resilient care infrastructure in Bangladesh would require an investment equivalent to roughly 3–5% of GDP, similar to what is needed for health and education. This is a substantial investment, but only a fraction of the estimated value of unpaid care work.

Building that care infrastructure would require millions of workers. We estimate that early-childhood care and education and long-term care could directly employ 3.6–7 million people in Bangladesh. More jobs would come from providing food and other supplies, as well as from building or retrofitting childcare facilities and homes for people receiving long-term care.

Care services also give financiers a concrete way to put adaptation money to work. For starters, such investments come with an established evidence base—data on unit costs, staffing models, utilization, and outcomes—facilitating risk assessment. Some of these investments partially pay for themselves through tax revenue from higher employment and lower future spending on health and social protection. And demand is demographically guaranteed, since the need for care can only grow as populations age.

As adaptation financing tightens, every dollar has to work harder. That makes it all the more important to invest in care systems that help communities withstand climate shocks while easing pressure on public budgets.